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Kinship and marriage among the Ashanti

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The obsolescence of widow remarriage is a symptom of the increasing divergence between the ties of fatherhood and marriage on the one hand, and those of matrilineal kinship on the other, which is found in Ashanti to-day. This is associated with the narrowing down of the lineage range within which precedent rights of inheritance are accepted—that is, the range within which the bond of siblingship is accepted as automatically binding.

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Siblings

Next to the bond between mother and child none is so strong as that between siblings by the same mother. Ashanti see that it is simply the tie between mother and child translated to the level of generation equality. The most important difference socially recognized between siblings is that of age. An older sibling is entitled to punish and reprimand a younger brother or sister and must be treated with deference. He is, conversely, obliged to help his juniors in trouble. This applies especially to the mother's first-born (*piesie*) who is regarded as the head of the sibling group and also receives special consideration from his or her parents. ¹ But in all other respects it is the equality and solidarity of siblings which Ashanti specially stress. The theme is common in discussions of the vicissitudes of marriage. 'Your brother or your sister, you can deny them nothing' is the way it is often put. Complete frankness and intimacy are possible only between siblings. Great as is the horror of incest, there are no avoidances between brother and sister. Ashanti are very particular about good manners and modesty of dress. It is  274 only between siblings that easy informality of manners and dress is allowed. Brothers and sisters may joke with each other, tease each other, and even quarrel, as they are prone to do in childhood, without causing offence. ¹ This

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accent on equality is not found in any other kinship relationship. It is felt to be immodest for adults of different generations to bath together; siblings of the same sex may do so. The attachment and mutual identification of sisters is notorious. Two sisters (in this case all women of the same generation in the lineage) cannot be the wives of one husband at the same time or in succession. They would quarrel incessantly—and so involve their immediate maternal kin in quarrels—because they cannot be kept separate in their relations with their husband. Sisters try to live together all their lives. A woman treats her sister's children so much like her own that orphan children often do not know whether their apparent mother is their true mother or her sister. This holds, though to a lesser degree (because of the legal inferiority of paternal ties), of brothers. Siblings think of one another's possessions as joint property. Borrowing between siblings cannot create debts ² and, as we know, a sibling is a person's first heir.

¹ It is the *piesie* whose birth transforms the woman into a parent (*obaatan*) and his or her position in the sibling group is unique for that reason. It is of interest that it is taboo for a *piesie* to have any contact with the medicine set up for twins. This accentuates his unique social position, the antithesis to which is a place in the sibling group that is shared.

¹ Conventionalized joking is not customary in any Ashanti kinship relationship. The nearest approach to a joking relationship is the privileged familiarity that obtains between Ashanti and some neighbouring **Akan** peoples like the Nzima.

² This applies also to all lineage kin, by contrast with other kin; but siblings (including children of full sisters) may borrow one another's personal goods without asking permission; other kin, except parents, may not. The borrowing and lending of money is in a class of its own. It is a common complaint that irrecoverable 'loans' cannot be withheld from lineage kin, but this complaint is seldom made of siblings. A brother or sister must be helped even if the circumstances of his need are blameworthy.

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